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Week 9 Discussion: Appeals

Following the TED Talk of Clint Smith called The Danger of Silence, I noticed the efficient use of pathos and ethos as methods for conveying the speaker's message. First of all, pathos can be seen in the way how Smith speaks about his personal experience of staying silent even though he had to speak out loud. Such experience gives an opportunity to the audience to think about situations when they remained silent because of being afraid. I think that such approach makes the speaker's message more persuasive because people will remember that their silence can lead to injustice. Another technique used by the speaker is ethos – it means that he is honest enough to confess his mistakes without blaming others. That is why he sounds more relatable.

In reflecting on my own essay regarding the use of rhetoric in a short story, I see that I already have used logos (appeal to logic), since I give examples from the story to back up my analysis. Similarly, I use pathos when talking about the emotions of the characters, their experience and difficulties, and how they affect the readers. Nevertheless, I can develop my essay further by giving additional quotations to explain how they prove my point. My thesis can be developed as well, which would give me additional ethos. Watching Smith's TED talk was useful for me because I understood that good writing is not only the presentation of the information but also the connection to the reader and the message itself.

Reference

Smith, C. (2014, July). The danger of silence [Video]. TED Conferences. https://www.ted.com/talks/clint_smith_the_danger_of_silence

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In the TED Talk titled The Danger of Silence by Clint Smith, one of the most compelling appeals that Smith makes is through pathos, which involves an appeal based on emotions. He gives personal anecdotes regarding instances where he did not say anything when he should have said something about some cases of injustice. This is meant to make the audience think about instances in their lives where they may have been silent when they knew something was wrong.

Smith also employs the use of ethos (credibility) through the revelation of his personal experiences. He is credible since he shows that he has an understanding of the implications of being quiet. This builds trust among the audience in the message being conveyed. The use of such appeals supports his main point that being quiet allows injustices to be perpetuated.

Thinking about the essay which I have written in analyzing the rhetoric of the short story, I have realized that I am also making use of the appeals of rhetoric. First, I am using logos through the presentation of my interpretations with examples. Second, I am also developing ethos by providing textual evidence on how I have arrived at my analysis. But I think that I need to further develop my essay by integrating more pathos when presenting the role of the experiences and emotions of the characters in moving the reader.s